



or software development. Those experiences helped me to understand operational activities.”

Jaswinder got into a techno-managerial role at a very early stage in his career. He began leading a team of 60 to 70 people as a Director within six years of his professional journey. “I got pushed into the management track very early in my career. If I could turn the clock back, I would have remained hands-on for longer, because the operation in India was growing. However, my management saw the managerial potential in me and thus in 1996, at the age of 32, I was made the Managing Director for Cadence India. In those days, that was unheard of for somebody that young getting that role.”

Many senior colleagues discouraged him by predicting the possibility of his failure. “However, it was *déjà vu* for me all over again. I took up the challenge,” Jaswinder says. In those initial days, he went through a lot of rapid learning phases, reached out, and tried to identify direct and indirect mentors from whom he could learn. Jaswinder says, “Fortunately, I must have done something right, so I am still in the company. When I took responsibility for the India operations, we were 100 odd people. Today, we are over 3,500 people at our four locations—Noida, Bengaluru, Pune, and Ahmedabad.”

Leading by example

Jaswinder says, “I feel that as an individual, I can accomplish very little. My success is entirely due



Jaswinder Ahuja receiving an ISA award from the hands of Nandan Nilekani

Key Contributions in the Indian Semiconductor & ESDM Sector

- Founding Member & President (Aug 2011 - Jan 2018), **VLSI Society of India**, a society established in 1991 to promote research and academics in VLSI and related fields
- Member of Executive Council (May 2006 - Apr 2010) & Chairman (May 2008-Apr 2009) at **India Electronics & Semiconductor Association (IESA)**, the apex body promoting the growth of the semiconductor related industry in India
- Member of the Advisory Board at **FabCi at IIT Hyderabad**, the first Fabless Chip Design Incubator funded by the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology, Government of India, May 2017 - Present
- Member of the Governing Council, **Software Technology Parks of India (STPI)**, May 2015 - Present
- Member PMG (Project Monitoring Group) & Member PET (Project Evaluation Team) & Mentor (2015 - Present), **Electropreneur Park**, an incubator set up to promote the development of IP and end products in the ESDM (Electronic System Design and Manufacturing) sector President

to the power of my team and the quality of the people around me. I try to enable them to maximise their contribution and value. I help them to channelise their energy. Thus, the key essence of my leadership is to enable, empower, and unleash the creativity, potential, and energy

of each team member. My management approaches are informal, very open.”

The dignity of labour has been an integral part of Jaswinder’s life. He rarely ever said no to anything that needed to be done, be it any opportunity that came, or anything that the company needed him to do. Jaswinder narrates, “Back in 1993-94, I was an engineering manager, leading 40 to 50 people with a relatively small setup and we had a project for building a new office setup. There was no facility person on our team. So, I took this project

“Firstly, entrepreneurs need to be very clear in their minds about the problem they are going to solve. Entrepreneurs need to be clear about the real value that they are bringing to the customers, that is, the value proposition. Secondly, they should understand both the local as well as global competitor landscape clearly so that they can make a widely acceptable offering. Thirdly, they should not get obsessed with their initial ideas and be open to accepting any information and insight-driven change for the benefit of their business.” — **Jaswinder Ahuja**